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China Battery Materials

Lithium into 4th week of June – 5M26 wrap-up of import dataset

CITI'S TAKE

China imported ~153k tons lithium carbonate in 5M26, +153% YoY and the imported volume touched an historical high at ~37.5k tons in May-26. Spodumene wise, China imported 2.74mn tons of spodumene in 5M26, up by 15% YoY. Australia continued to take up the largest share, accounting for 58%, though its share has been down vs 65% in 5M25 and 62% in 2025. Africa accelerated the spodumene export, especially Nigeria and Mali, taking up 37% of China's spodumene import in 5M26, vs 25% in 5M25 and 30% in 2025 respectively. Lithium price has been under pressure with hovering concern on JXW resumption, albeit lithium S/D dynamics remained tight and de-stocking extended for another week. Reiterate our bullish view as expect lithium S/D dynamics may continue to be tight as lots of new battery capacities are scheduled in 3Q26. even taking account of JXW resumption.

Weekly wrap-up: Lithium **ASP** was in the downtrend WoW during last week. Among that, Li₂CO₃ and LiOH ASP is quoted at Rmb157k/t and Rmb143.5k/t as of 25th June respectively, vs Rmb167.25k/t and Rmb152.5k/t as of 18th June. **Production wise**, China Li₂CO₃ production was +1% WoW at 26,642 tons last week. Among that, output from brine, lepidolite, spodumene, and recycle was flattish/+1%/+1%/+1% WoW respectively. **Inventory wise**, total inventory of Li₂CO₃ came in at 95,812 tons this week (-1% WoW / -833 tons WoW). Within that, inventory of downstream players (mainly cathode makers), smelters, and others (mainly battery makers and traders) were +3%, +1%, -7% WoW to 48,285 tons, 15,373 tons, and 34,582 tons respectively.

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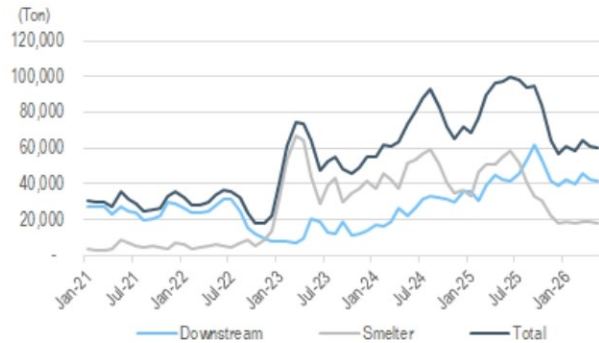
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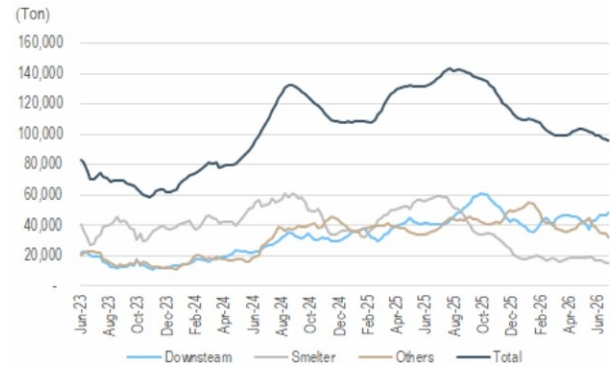
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Figure 1. Lithium carbonate monthly inventory



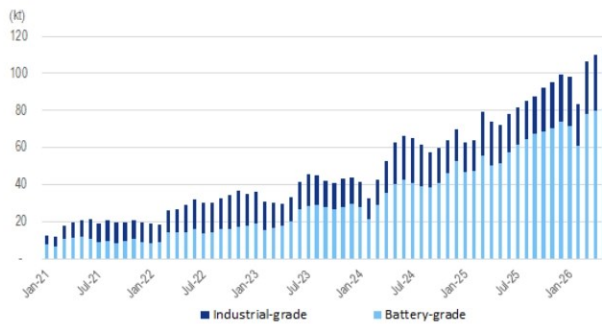
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Figure 2. Lithium carbonate weekly inventory



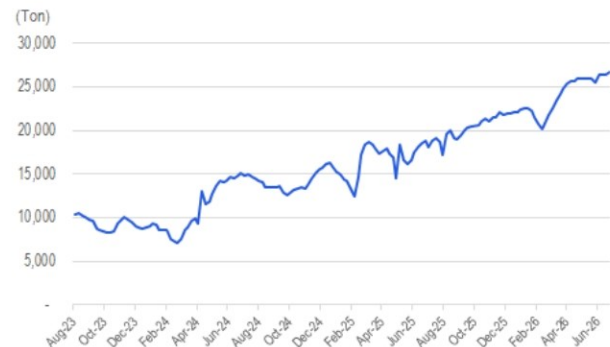
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Figure 3. Lithium carbonate monthly production



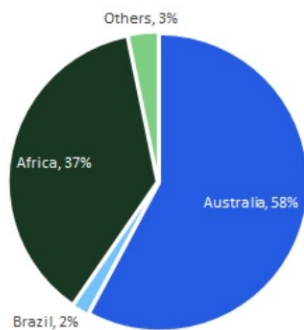
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Figure 4. Lithium carbonate weekly production



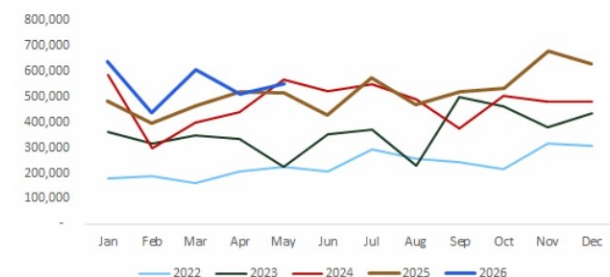
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Figure 5. 5M26 spod import by country



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Figure 6. Monthly spodumene import vol (tons)



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